

Narratives in Chuj

THIS COLLECTION OF SIX narratives told in Chuj demonstrates the broad variety of stories people tell one another and the variety of sources of those stories: personal narratives, legendary events, mythological tales, and stories borrowed from other cultures. All were recorded by me during field work on Chuj from 1964 to 1965. (See the Archive of the Indigenous Languages of Latin America, www.ailla.utexas.org, for these and other samples of Chuj speech recorded during field work; AILLA reference codes for each text are given below and at the head of each transcription.)

Introduction to the Texts

Two of the stories are ultimately of foreign origin, but their origins are not the same. In one case, the story known to the narrator as *An Old Man Whose Son Killed Him* [CAC 002 R022], the story clearly comes from the European tradition, and must have been introduced to the Chuj by schoolteachers. It is the classic Greek tale of a couple whose child is destined to kill his father and how that came about, including the solution to a famous riddle: What animal walks on four legs at dawn, on two legs at noon, and on three legs in the evening?

The other tale, *Coyote and Rabbit* [CAC 002 R027], is probably ultimately of African origin, although some of its episodes are traditional in the American South and may have been introduced secondhand to the Chuj. This is the series of incidents that make up the *Br'er Rabbit* stories, stories that reflected earlier African tales involving Hyena instead of Fox (Diarassouba 2007). Here the story features Coyote instead of either Fox or Hyena. Coyote stories and stories of Rabbit Trickster abound in the native New World, and some of the episodes may be of American origin, adapted to the framework of the African stories. Some episodes have a local flavor (such as misty mountains) and are likely of local origin.

A third story, *Friend of the Animals* [CAC 002 R020], expresses such a universal theme that it could possibly be of foreign origin as well, but it has